PROJECT WORTH

GROOMING AWARENESS FOR NONPROFITS

EVERY ROLE HAS INFLUENCE

Children may place deep trust in staff, volunteers, mentors, coaches, drivers, contractors, board members, and program leaders.

Grooming is a pattern used to gain access, trust, secrecy, loyalty, or control.

It may happen through gifts, favoritism, private communication, transportation, mentoring, physical contact, social media, gaming, virtual meetings, or other one to one access.

Strong organizations build clear boundaries, safe reporting pathways, consistent supervision, and accountability into every role.

KNOW THE SIGNS

Pay attention when someone:

- Seeks unusual access to a child
- Creates secrecy or private communication
- Gives excessive attention, gifts, or privileges
- Tests physical, emotional, or digital boundaries
- Creates dependence, guilt, fear, loyalty, or confusion
- Ignores supervision, transportation, or communication rules

Patterns, secrecy, access, authority, and boundary violations matter.

STRONG ORGANIZATIONS REDUCE OPPORTUNITY

- Clear rules for one to one contact, transportation, overnight activities, gifts, bathrooms, changing areas, and electronic communication
- Screening, reference checks, background checks, supervision, and ongoing monitoring
- Reporting options outside the direct chain of command
- Documentation, training, and consistent follow through

Background checks are one layer of protection, not a complete prevention system.

WHEN A CONCERN IS RAISED

- Listen calmly
- Do not investigate, interrogate, or promise secrecy
- Document concerns
- Limit unsafe access when appropriate
- Report suspected abuse or neglect as required
- Protect the person who raised the concern from retaliation

BUILD A CULTURE THAT PROTECTS CHILDREN

Policies protect children only when they are understood, practiced, enforced, and reviewed.

Children are safer when adults document concerns, challenge unsafe behavior, and act before harm escalates.

REPORT CONCERNS

If a child is in immediate danger, call 911.

Wisconsin reports may be made to local child protective services or law enforcement.

PROTECTING CHILDREN IS EVERYONE'S RESPONSIBILITY.

Together, we light up the darkness.

Project Worth | Protecting Kids | Changing Systems | Empowering Survivors

projectworthwi.org | info@projectworthwi.org